Script 1 — IE CSAI Student

Opening: "We're students working on a project about how people our age get their first tech role. I'd like to ask about things you've actually done recently — there's nothing to sell you. Can I take notes without your name?"

Q1. Think about the last internship or junior role you applied to. Walk me through what the application actually asked you for.
"It was a junior backend role at a startup here in Madrid, through LinkedIn. CV obviously, then a field for a portfolio or GitHub link, and at the bottom a box saying 'tell us about a project you've worked on and what your role was.' Max 300 words. I spent longer on that box than on the rest of the form."

Q2. What did you put in that box, or link to? Walk me through what you chose and why that one.
"I put the group project from my web development class — we built a booking site for a gym, a made-up gym. It was the only thing I had that looked finished. I remember thinking it's obviously a uni project and they're going to know that, but what else am I going to put, the Python exercises? So I wrote it up to sound as real as I could."

Q3. Did anyone — a form, a recruiter, an interviewer — ask you to explain what you personally did on it? What happened?
"Yeah. In the first call he asked 'so which parts did you write?' and I kind of froze. We did it together, we were all in the same room for two weeks, we all touched everything. I said I did most of the frontend and some of the database, but I could hear myself and it sounded vague. He didn't follow up, he just moved on, which felt worse. I had nothing to show him that proved it was me."

Q4. What happened with that application? And did you do anything differently afterwards?
"Nothing. I never heard back, not even a rejection. That was March. After that I started a side project on my own — a thing that tracks football stats — specifically so I'd have something that was only mine. I got about 60% through it. I also asked a friend from my year who got into a consultancy if he could refer me, which felt a bit desperate but whatever."

Q5. In the last six months, what have you built to have something to show? Take the most recent one — how it started, roughly how much time, how it ended.
"The football stats thing. It started because I saw a tutorial and thought I could do a better version. I worked on it three weekends in a row, pretty intensely, then exams hit and I stopped. It's still sitting in a branch. The annoying part is I don't even know if what I built is any good — nobody's looked at it. There's no point where someone says yeah, that's done, that's fine. So you either keep adding stuff or you stop."

Q6. Have you used Forage, HackerRank, Devpost, Kaggle, anything like that? Walk me through the last time.
"I did two Forage ones, the JPMorgan one and a Deloitte one. They take four or five hours and at the end you compare your answer to the model answer and it says well done. It's fine, but it felt fake.

Nobody checked anything I did. I put them on LinkedIn and nobody has ever mentioned them to me."

Q7. Have you ever paid money for something to improve your chances of getting hired? What, how much, and what made you decide right then?
"I paid for LeetCode Premium for two months, about 35 a month. I did it because I had a technical interview coming up in two weeks and I panicked. And I bought a React course on Udemy on sale for 15 euros, although I did about a third of it. So yeah, I've paid when there was something specific coming up."

Now describe the idea, flat, including the price:
"A company gives us a real, small brief — about four hours of work. You do it, alone or in a team of up to three. Automated tests and an AI rubric score every submission, and an engineer at that company signs off the rubric and reviews the top ones. You get a score, a breakdown, written feedback, and a record of what you personally did, on a link you can share. The score is free; the certified version costs €15."

Q8. First reaction — what would make you not bother?
"Timing, mainly. If it's November and I've got two deliverables due, four hours is a lot. And I'd want to know who the company is — if it's a name people recognise, the score actually means something to a recruiter. The other thing is what happens if I do badly. If a bad score is attached to my name somewhere public, that's worse for me than not doing it at all."

Q9. Say you'd done it and the score came back. What would you actually do with it?
"I'd put the link in my CV, under projects. And on LinkedIn — people post certificates on there constantly. And if I got to an interview I'd bring up the feedback, like, an engineer at this company said this about my code. That's a much better thing to say than 'I built a gym booking site for class.'"

Q10. The certified result is €15. Is that something you'd pay for? What would it have to do to be worth it? Can I send you the link when the pilot opens on 16 October?
"Fifteen euros is two coffees. If I'd already done the work and the feedback was real — an actual engineer wrote it, not generated — I'd pay that, especially if I can put it on LinkedIn. What would make it worth it is the feedback being specific, like telling me what a junior at a real company would have done differently. Yeah, send me the link."

Q11. If you saw this on a classmate's profile, what would make you think it meant nothing?
"If everyone in my year had one. The second it's on fifty profiles it's noise, like those LinkedIn course badges. And if the money is what gets you the certificate rather than the work, then it's worthless, obviously. It has to be possible to fail it."
Close: "Who else should I talk to — anyone in your year applying right now?"

Script 2 — Recruiter at Edukko “Tamara”

Has screened at least one tech intern or junior in the last 12 months. 15 minutes. Bring two anonymised profiles: same CV, one with a SkillBridge certificate attached.

Opening: "We're a university team researching how tech interns get screened. Fifteen minutes, no pitch — at the end I'll show you a mock profile and ask what you'd do with it. Can I take notes without your name or your company's?"

Q1. The last intern or junior opening you screened — roughly how many applications, and how long did you spend on each at the first pass?
"For the summer internship we had around 400 applications for six places. First pass is me and one other person and we're spending ninety seconds each, less. You scan for a few things and if none of them are there you move on. It's not a careful process, I'll be honest with you."

Q2. Walk me through the last candidate you rejected at CV stage that you weren't sure about. What was missing?
"There was one recently — good degree, decent grades, and the projects section was three lines of 'developed a web application using React and Node.' So did four hundred other people. There was nothing I could look at, nothing that told me whether this person can build something or whether they followed a tutorial. I'd have interviewed them if there'd been anything concrete. That one bugged me."

Q3. When a candidate's only experience is coursework and personal projects, what do you do with that? Do you open the GitHub link?
"Sometimes. Maybe one in ten, if something else caught my eye first. And when I do open it, half the time it's a group project and I genuinely cannot tell which parts were theirs — the commits are all over the place, or there's one massive commit from one person. So it doesn't tell me much, which is why I usually don't bother."

Q4. Do you run a take-home or technical assessment? At what stage, how long, and what does it cost your team in hours?
"Yes, after the first screen. It's meant to be three hours. Two of our engineers review them, twenty minutes each, so for a round of twenty candidates that's a lot of engineering time and they hate doing it. The drop-off is brutal too, we lose about a third who never submit. And now there's the AI problem — I don't know anymore whether I'm assessing the candidate or a model."

Q5. Has a certificate or credential on a profile ever changed a decision you made? Which one, and what happened?
"AWS, yeah. Someone had the Solutions Architect associate and that moved them forward, because it's a real exam, it's proctored, you can't fake it, and it told me they'd put in the hours. Most of the others I skip. The difference is there's a pass mark that means something and somebody independent checked."

Now show both profiles, without explaining them.
Q6. Same role, both of these in your pile. Which do you take forward, and why?
"This one. There's something here I can actually look at — it says what the task was, what they scored, and there's a note from an engineer who read the code. The other one I'm just reading adjectives the candidate wrote about themselves."

Q7. What in there do you actually trust, and what would you skip over?

"The written feedback is the useful part, assuming a real person wrote it. The number I'd skip — 82 out of 100 means nothing to me on its own, I don't know what the distribution is. And I'd want to know whose rubric it is. If it's the hiring company's rubric and their engineer signed it, that's the part with weight."

Q8. Would you accept this instead of your take-home? If not, what would it take?
"Maybe — if the brief came from us and one of our engineers had signed it off. Then it's basically our take-home, done earlier. I'd still want thirty minutes live to check they can talk about what they wrote. But it would save the review time, which is the expensive part."

Q9. What would make you suspect this was gamed, or that AI did most of it?
"If I saw three of them and the submissions all looked the same. Or if there's no live component at all — anything done unsupervised at home right now, I assume a model helped. The fix is someone being able to explain their own work for ten minutes."

Q10. If candidates from a university you recruit from routinely had these, would you start asking for them? And would your company pay for access to candidates' results — out of which budget, instead of what?
"If it were standard at IE I'd notice its absence, which is the same thing. Paying — possibly. We already pay for LinkedIn Recruiter and we sponsored a hackathon last year, about eight thousand out of the talent-brand budget. If this replaced the take-home review time I could make that case. My head of talent signs off anything over five."

Script 3 — Nice strategies engineer “Jose Carlos”

Engineer at a SaaS, engineering or data company who could own a brief. 10 minutes. You need a brief and a rubric out of this conversation.
Opening: "We're a university team running a two-week pilot. I'm not asking for money or a hire — I'm asking whether there's a small piece of work you'd be curious to see ten students attempt, and whether you'd say what 'good' looks like."

Q1. Is there something in your backlog that's real but nobody has time for — self-contained, no production access, no customer data, maybe four hours for a decent junior?
"Actually, yes. We've got a CSV import thing — customers send us messy spreadsheets and someone cleans them by hand every time. A script that validates the file and flags the bad rows would be genuinely useful, and it's been in the backlog about a year because it's never urgent. I could give you three example files with nothing sensitive in them."

Q2. If ten students sent you solutions to that, what would you look at first to decide whose was good? Give me four or five things.
"Does it run on a file I give it that it hasn't seen. Does it handle the broken rows sensibly instead of crashing. Is the code readable — would I understand it in six months. Did they write any tests, even one. And is there a readme that tells me how to run it, because you'd be amazed. Those five, in that order."

Q3. How long would it take you to review the top three? And what would make you say no to doing this a second time?
"Twenty minutes each, so about an hour. I'd do it again — honestly if one of them was good I'd want to talk to them, we're always looking. What would make me say no is if it turned into a thing with meetings and coordination. Send me three zips and a deadline and I'm fine."

Q4. If an AI scored all ten against your criteria and you only saw the top three — would you trust the filter? What would you check?
"I'd spot-check one from the bottom, just to see that it's actually bad and the thing isn't ranking randomly. If that holds up once or twice I'd stop worrying about it."

Q5. Who owns what the students produce? Is that a conversation you'd have to have with someone?
"I'd assume they keep it, it's their code. If we ever wanted to actually use the script I'd need to ask legal and that's a two-week thing. Easier if we say up front that it stays theirs and we're not using it."

Q6. Would you interview someone off the back of this? And is this something a company would pay for, instead of what?
"If someone nailed it, yes, I'd forward them to our recruiter — that's free sourcing for us. Paying isn't my call. We spend on hackathon sponsorships, a few thousand last year, and we pay for a screening tool. If it saved the engineers the take-home review there's an argument. Talk to our talent person."
The ask before you hang up: "Can I send you four to six criteria in writing by Thursday and get a yes or an edit back? That's the only commitment I need."